

CORE FORMULA

Receive -> Appreciate -> Summarise -> Ask -> Receive: give full attention and take in what they actually said. **-> Appreciate:** acknowledge the contribution or feeling with a small, genuine signal. **-> Summarise:** reflect the core meaning back in one line. **-> Ask:** follow with one useful question that moves it forward. **-> Field rule:** use the structure to organise thought, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Silently run the four steps, then say one line that reflects the core point back and asks a single useful question — without ever naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Active listening and making someone feel accurately heard
- Sensitive or emotional conversations handled with care
- Coaching, mentoring and reflective supervision
- One-to-ones where someone is thinking out loud
- Organising a concise contribution under pressure
- Meetings and updates where you want a point to land clearly

PHRASE BANK

Quick reflect-and-ask · Short one-liners

- "So the main thing is X — have I got that right?"
- "Let me make sure I've got it: the key point is X."
- "What matters most here, in one line?"
- "So, if I heard you right?"
- "The heart of it seems to be X. What's the next question?"
- "Say more about the part that matters most."
- "Where would it help to go from here?"
- "Quick check — is X the bit that really counts?"

Receive & appreciate · Warmth and acknowledgement

- "Thanks for laying that out — I can tell you've thought about it."
- "I appreciate you talking me through it."
- "That's a lot to hold. I'm glad you said it."
- "I can see why that matters to you."
- "There's real care in how you put that."
- "I'm following you — keep going."
- "That makes sense, and I appreciate the honesty."
- "I want to get this right, so let me reflect it back."

Meetings & email · Work and decision contexts

- "Let me summarise where we've landed: we're aligned on the timeline, and you want to revisit the budget."
- "So the decision on the table is X. Have I framed that fairly?"
- "Here's what I'm hearing as the priority — tell me if I've missed anything."
- "To keep this useful: the core issue is X, and the rest is context."
- "I'll keep this short, then we can adjust it together."
- "Summarising for the notes: X is agreed, Y is still open."

- "The main point is X; everything else is support."
- "Before we move on — what would be the most useful next step?"

Summarise & ask · Clean reflect plus one question

- "The key point seems to be X. What would be useful to explore next?"
- "So what I'm taking from that is X. Is that the crux?"
- "If I'm honest, the real question underneath this is X."
- "Let me name it plainly: X. What do you want to do about it?"
- "That's the summary. What's the one thing you need from me?"
- "So the choice is between X and Y — which one pulls at you more?"
- "Given all that, what's the next concrete step?"

Reset the structure · Softening a mechanical moment

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Forget the tidy version — what actually matters to you here?"
- "Let me check whether that structure is helping or just sounding neat."
- "Ignore my summary for a second — did I miss the real point?"

Sensitive & emotional · Validate before you structure

- "Before I try to tidy this up — how are you actually doing with it?"
- "I don't want to summarise too soon. Take your time."
- "Let me sit with what you said before I say anything back."
- "That sounds really hard. I just want to make sure I've heard it."
- "I could reflect it back, but first — is there more you need to say?"
- "The point can wait. What do you need right now?"
- "I want to get this right, because it clearly matters."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Using RASA as a visible script and sounding rehearsed.

Better: Using RASA silently to organise a concise response.

Best: Using RASA flexibly, then checking whether the person is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.

2. Weak: Announcing the framework and forcing every sentence into the four steps.

Better: Moving through the steps quietly, without naming any of them.

Best: Noticing when a different move is needed and adapting without defending the structure.

3. Weak: Jumping to your summary before they've finished talking.

Better: Receiving fully, then reflecting the core point back.

Best: Receiving, appreciating and summarising so accurately that they say "exactly".

DECISION TREE

If They need speed

Compress to one reflect-and-ask line and skip the appreciate step.

"The key point is X. What's the next step?"

If They're carrying emotion

Validate first and delay the summary until they feel heard.

"That sounds heavy. I'm here — take your time."

If They need to tell the story

Switch to an example-led structure like STAR or CARL and let them narrate.

"Walk me through what happened, start to finish."

If They need a decision or action

Run the structure quickly, then close on one clean next step.

"So the point is X. Shall we agree the next step?"

If They look confused by the framing

Summarise once and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

"Have I got that right, or have I missed the real point?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Run the structure silently, then contribute one concise, memorable summary. — "So we're aligned on the timeline; the open question is budget. What do we want to decide today?"

Email or written update

Put each step into short, scannable paragraphs or bullets. — "Here's what I heard, what I value in it, the core point, and one question for you."

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback would help before you structure anything. — "Would it help to hear my read on it, or do you mainly want to think out loud?"

Difficult conversation

Use one sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — "I hear you. I get why it matters. The core seems to be X. What would help now?"

Coaching or mentoring

Weight the Ask — reflect briefly, then hand the thinking back. — "So the sticking point is X. What options have you already considered?"

Someone in distress

Stay on Receive and Appreciate; don't summarise until they feel heard. — "That's a lot to carry. I'm not going to rush you — say as much as you need."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Urgent instruction, where people need to act rather than be summarised
- Legalistic correction or fixed procedure
- High-risk decisions that need direct, immediate action
- Moments when summarising would feel premature
- Raw distress, shame or grief, where validation must come first
- When physical safety or an emergency response takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Learn the four steps

Memorise Receive -> Appreciate -> Summarise -> Ask, then write one sentence for each step drawn from a real conversation you had today.

Day 2 — Draft a full response

Take a real message or comment and write a 60-second reply that moves through all four steps in order.

Day 3 — Cut it back

Trim yesterday's response by a third without losing the core point. Notice which words were scaffolding.

Day 4 — Say it two ways

Read it aloud once as a visible structure and once as plain speech. Keep only the version that sounds human.

Day 5 — Summarise live

In one real conversation, reflect the core point back in a single sentence and watch whether they say "exactly" or correct you.

Day 6 — Lead with appreciate

In a sensitive moment, receive and appreciate first — hold the summary until they've fully finished.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Catch yourself sounding mechanical, and use one recovery line to reset the conversation back to plain speech.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use RASA to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear by the end?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Did I adapt when they needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?
- Did I actually listen, or just run the steps?